

CHAPTER 3

MENTAL TRAINING

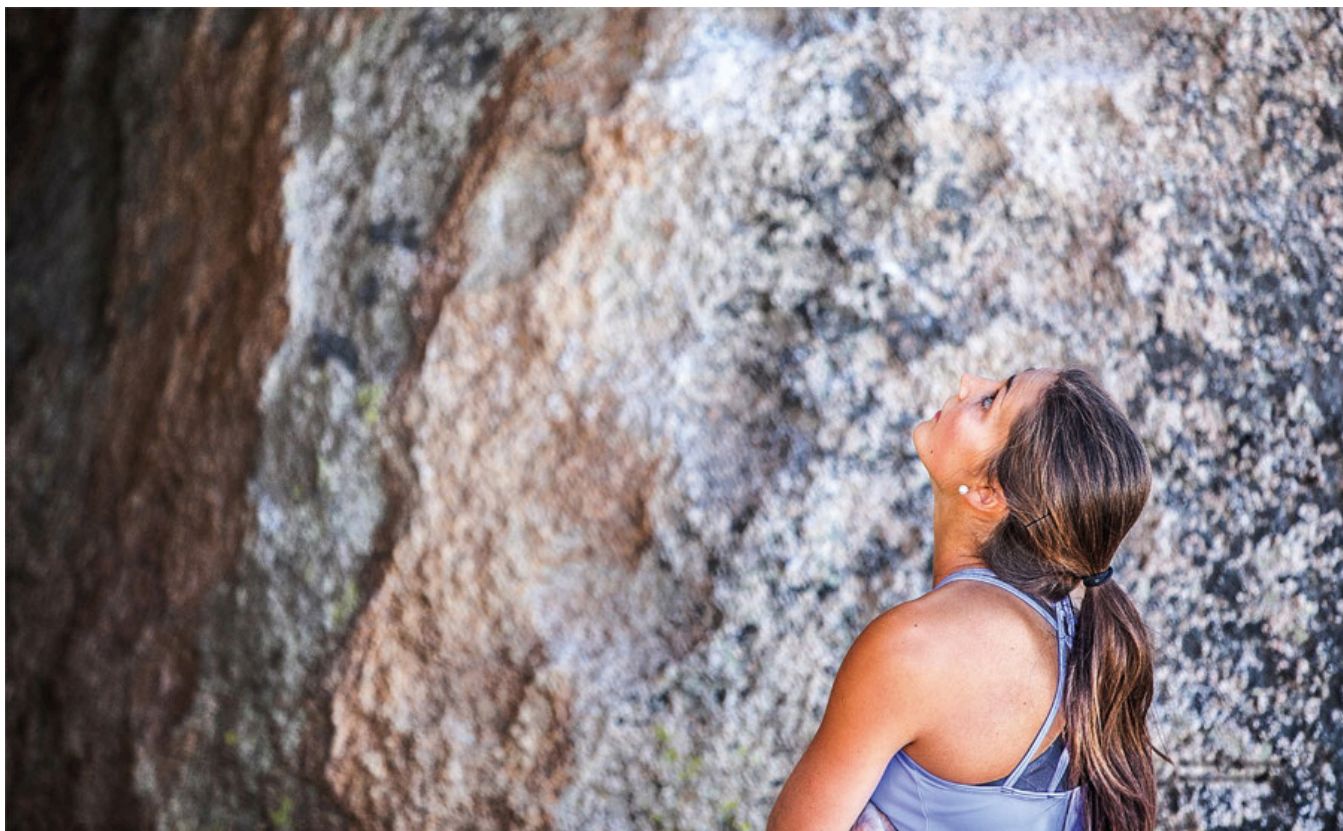


PHOTO: ALEX MANELIS

Maria Davies Sandbu preparing before an attempt in Bishop, USA.

‘THE BRAIN IS THE MOST IMPORTANT MUSCLE FOR CLIMBING.’

WOLFGANG GÜLLICH, THE FIRST PERSON TO CLIMB F9a

GÜLLICH’S QUOTE IS used in virtually all articles and books that deal with mental training for climbing. And not without reason: the quote hits the nail on the head. For example, you might have experienced getting scared and forgetting everything you know about technique as you climbed past the last bolt when leading a route, or how a lack of confidence on a climb can lead you to hesitate and fall. In the chapter on technique, we highlighted the mental aspect as an important element for doing dynamic moves, and in the physical training chapter, we emphasised the mental factors around getting pumped. Your mentality will affect every part of your climb, so it is just as important that you train your head as well as the physical and technical sides of your climbing.

In this chapter, we look at how mental techniques improve mental skills, which in turn increase climbing performance. Better mental skills mean that in the long run you will be able to make better use of your potential, and this can make the difference between whether you reach your goals or not. At the same time, it will also give you more enjoyment of the sport of climbing. Not only because you'll perform better, but also because you'll learn how to better deal with the ups and downs of climbing – and not just the literal!

MOTIVATION AND SETTING GOALS

Motivation is essential if you wish to become a better climber. You must be motivated to put in the effort needed when strength training, and you have to be motivated to practise precise footwork in order to improve your technique. We believe that the most important thing for motivation is that you find joy in what you are doing. If you're enjoying it, you'll pull harder during your strength training sessions and have more patience when working on technical elements. If you find pleasure in training for climbing, we recognise this as having an inner motivation to climb, train and improve. Unlike external motivation, where you are motivated by results, rewards or recognition by others, you will find joy in pursuing the activity itself and being motivated by mastery and progression. The chances of you being willing to do what it takes to progress, to cope with the harder days with a smile and continue climbing for years and years, is much greater if your motivation is intrinsically rooted. If you win a competition or get recognition for a climb, take it as a well-deserved bonus, but don't let that be the only reason you're climbing. Instead, try to feel the joy of learning a new technique or sticking yet another move on your project.



Specific Measurable Ambitious Realistic Time limited

An important technique for staying motivated is goal setting. Since motivation should come from internal factors and is dependent on progression and mastery, your goals should reflect this. Many climbers aim to climb a certain route or grade. They specifically train for a long time to send the route, and in the end, they might achieve their goal. The problem with such goals is that the road to victory can seem unrealistically long. Therefore, it may be good to set goals that let you know that you are progressing. For example, try to climb multiple routes of a particular style, get physically stronger or become less afraid of falling on lead. With these goals, each individual performance becomes less important, and it is easier to find joy in progress and not just in success.

It will be of great benefit to you if the goals you set follow the principles of SMART and are clearly defined. For example, a well-defined goal could be to climb five vertical routes graded F6b by the end of the year. This goal is specific, measurable and within a predefined time limit. At the same time, it is both an ambitious, yet realistic goal if you have just started with climbing 'in the sixes', it's early in the year and you have been training well throughout the winter.

GRADE	TOTAL	
7a	7	
6c+	18	
6c	60	
6b+	75	
6b	86	

A ticklist shaped like a pyramid shows that you've built up a good foundation of skills at lower levels. All of these routes and boulder problems can be viewed as intermediate goals on the Path of Progression, and perhaps some of these were indeed your main goal at the time?

It's beneficial to define sub-goals in addition to your main goals, as this ensures that you'll experience progression and mastery along the way. If your goal is to establish yourself on a new grade by, for example, having climbed three routes of that grade the coming season, each route can be a sub-goal on its own. In addition, another sub-goal might be to do several routes one grade below your target. To become a good climber you should always make sure your ticklist is shaped like a pyramid. In addition to the sub-goals, it's wise to set goals for the climbing session you're about to have. This is important and allows you to get a sense of achievement for each session and helps you to perform at your maximum. Such goals might be to do another move on your project or to figure out and send a sequence you've yet to complete. It could also be to achieve the feeling of really going all out in an endurance session, or doing an extra pull-up if you are doing a strength training session.

By varying the focus of your training and your goals for different periods of the year, you can more easily maintain motivation. If you have spent some time working on your technique, it can be good for your motivation to switch things up and work on your physique for a while, and vice versa. You can also have several different goals for the same period: you could focus on technical and balancy boulder problems on easy days, and arm and upper body strength on harder days. For many of us, it is the complexity of climbing which makes it so exciting, and the variety this provides in your training should be utilised to the fullest to keep your motivation up.



Remember, grades are very subjective and routes and boulder problems can feel hard or easy for different climbers, based on their height, finger size, climbing style, and so on. It might be harder for you to climb an 'easy' route that doesn't suit you than it is to set a new personal best on a route that suits your style perfectly. Sending a new grade is therefore not a very objective way of measuring progression.



PHOTO: ALEX MANELIS

Thilo Schröter playing around on The Rhino (Font 7b+), Rocklands, South Africa.



THILO SCHRÖTER:

•The quality of what you're doing is more important than what it is you're actually doing. Adjust your training according to how you feel from day to day and make sure you get enough rest. Knowing when your body needs a rest day takes more discipline and insight than the training itself.

•A good training partner is worth his or her weight in gold! Train together with people who push you and feed you with energy and inspiration – and preferably someone who's a bit better than you.

ADVERSITY

Progression makes it easier to stay motivated, but at times motivation can and will be off on holiday. Stagnation, and even periodic decline, can be demotivating, and it is no secret that the times when you feel clumsy and weak will leave their mark on your mood and affect the quality of your workout. If you ever find yourself lacking in motivation, there are two things you can do:

- Find the reason that you feel weak. You may be in a heavy training period which will naturally reduce your performance in the short term. Remember, you're training hard now to become even stronger later. You might be experiencing a lot of stress in other areas of your life. If so, it's only natural for progression to slow down, but when you analyse why, you can be confident that you will come back even stronger. You can't be in the best shape of your life every time you put your shoes on. By accepting this, you will perform better by reducing the performance expectation for each session.

- Find pleasure in achieving other things in life. Climbing shouldn't be the only thing that defines who you are, even though it might feel like it sometimes. Remember that you are also a source of motivation for your training partners and those around you. Get psyched by others doing well, and be positive so that they can perform at their best. By being positive you'll help to create a positive training culture that will lift both yourself and others. Most of us prefer to train with positive climbing partners, so try to be one yourself too.



It's best to surround yourself with positive climbers and to be positive yourself. It's impossible not to be negatively affected by whining climbers. Try to avoid them – and don't become one!

CONFIDENCE AND INNER DIALOGUE

Confidence is the belief that you'll be able to do whatever it is you're trying to do, whether it's your first pull-up or not slipping off that tiny foothold on the technical slab problem you're working on. Confidence is important for pushing yourself during training and when you're about to try a hard route or boulder problem. Confidence isn't something we just have; it's created by actively working with having faith in succeeding. If we do just that, we can drastically increase our chance of success. One of the true legends of bouldering, Marc Le Menestrel, once said that he needed 'A little bit of magic' to send a boulder problem in the magical forest of Fontainebleau. Our experience is that this magic doesn't appear without the belief that it will.

Your preparations – and especially being conscious about being prepared – are important for your confidence. By trusting your preparations, you'll build faith in succeeding in the tasks at hand. Engaging in a positive inner dialogue – i.e. talking to yourself – is an important mental technique to further build your confidence. On average, 150 to 300 words per minute will be popping into your head, and these words will affect your performance. So it's important to try to control your thoughts. Tell yourself that you will accomplish what you're trying to achieve. Repeat to yourself how well prepared you are, and establish faith in your success. It is also helpful to remind yourself of previous positive experiences and relive them in your mind. For example, before doing a hard strength training session, think back to the last time you had a really good training session. When the session has started, say to yourself that you'll do that last pull-up in your programme. This will put you in the right mindset to pull hard and increase your faith in actually doing it. Before trying a really hard route, think back to the last time you climbed something hard. By reliving past successes before performing, your faith in yourself will increase. When you're on a route, practise telling yourself that you're feeling good and that you'll be able to send. Convince yourself that you're strong enough, that you won't get too pumped, and that you're climbing with good technique. Try to suppress the feeling of getting pumped, and don't allow any mistakes that you might make damage your confidence. It's imperative that anything you tell yourself is helping to boost your confidence.

Since positive experiences have a reinforcing effect on your confidence, it is important that you take care of them and spend enough time memorising them so that you can easily retrieve them at a later date. Negative experiences, on the other hand, should be analysed: find out what went wrong and why it happened, and then try to forget these experiences. Learn from the mistakes, but do not relive the experiences themselves. It is said that you need ten positive experiences to make up for one negative, and by remembering the negative, this discrepancy will be even greater. If you fail to climb a route, try smiling and laughing instead of beating yourself up – and then try again. We're not saying that you should never get mad – it's OK to vent your frustration – but you must try to avoid letting it get to you so that it affects you negatively. Remember we are falling all the time! Don't be too hard on yourself every time you fail: climbing is failing until you make it. Some climbers project routes for days, weeks and even years before sending them. When you come home after training or trying a project, you can analyse what went wrong, set a plan for how to prevent it from happening again, and then put it away.

HESITATION

You might have noticed how hesitation leads you to climb poorly, and sometimes fall.

Is my foot going to slip? Will I be able to reach the next hold? Am I going to clip the quickdraw? In the same way, you might have experienced days where you're confidently smearing on the tiniest of footholds and hitting every

handhold perfectly. This is the difference between days where you have low confidence and days where you have faith in your success. A quote from one of our English climbing colleagues is, 'A weighted foot never slips'. If you believe you're standing on the foothold, you'll also apply more pressure with your foot, maximise friction and lessen the risk of your foot slipping.



PHOTO: HENNING WANG

Maria Davies Sandbu fighting to clip the draws on Kalea Borroka (F8b+), Siurana, Spain.

TRY, FAIL AND FAIL BETTER!

Positive thinking isn't only important when climbing hard. It is easier to learn when you're relaxed and in a positive state of mind. Positive thinking is therefore important every time you train – so focus on getting better at it. The best way to do this is to become conscious of how you're thinking. By being conscious of thinking positively and suppressing negative thoughts, you will eventually become significantly better at having a positive inner dialogue. Eventually, you'll automatically think positively, and you won't have to spend as much energy on it. Then, when you are trying hard on a route that you want to send, you can instead use your mental energy to focus on other tasks.

Be aware of when negative thoughts arise and decide if they are prudent. A simple tool for turning a negative inner dialogue into a positive one is the so-called 'thought stop'. When you notice that you're starting to think negatively – for example, 'the conditions are bad', 'my skin is bad', 'my endurance is bad' – you can perform a physical action that stops this line of thinking and turns your attention to the positive. This action can be as simple as pinching your arm or asking your climbing partner to let you know if you start talking yourself down. The most important thing is that you become aware of your inner dialogue and can turn it from a negative to a positive. Below are some tips for positive talking points which are based on the negative thoughts climbers often have.

- I'm well prepared because I've trained for what I'm about to do!
- I like challenging myself!
- I'm not too short. I can place my feet higher!
- I'm not too tall. I often don't have to place my feet high, and can reach further!
- It's OK to not have a lot of time. I'll just plan ahead and use the time more sensibly!

DARE TO TRY

In order to create positive experiences and build confidence at all, you must dare to try. Fall if you are afraid of falling. Challenge yourself with dynamic movements if you are poor at them. Don't be afraid to make a fool of yourself in front of other climbers. You must, as with all other elements of your life, extend your comfort zone and push yourself. If things go wrong, analyse them and learn from them. If you do not even try, the positive experiences will not come! Nothing will slow your progression more.



You must know your fears and why they exist. Write them down – and write down what you're doing to conquer them!

FEAR OF FALLING

Most of us have a certain degree of fear of heights, and it can feel quite unnatural and scary for us to let go of a hold and rely on gear and the belayer when climbing on lead, or a spotter and pads when bouldering. Most beginners get scared when climbing on lead, but also more experienced climbers can be impeded from performing at their best because of their fear of falling. Fear makes us move less proficiently. We stop trusting our feet, and we grip the holds more than is necessary and thus use more force than we need.

Having a basic fear of and respect for heights where the consequence of a fall is potentially serious is an important survival mechanism, and fear is, therefore, a rational response. When we know that the gear will hold, that safety checks have been completed and the belayer is ready and attentive, the fear of falling is irrational.

Fear is appropriate as it enables us to make rational choices about safety, but irrational fear should not prevent us from performing. If it does, we must actively work on it so we can better deal with it. How long it will take to become less scared will vary from climber to climber, but it will be better if you expose yourself to falling on a regular basis. Some climbers might be better off starting easy and getting used to falling gradually, while for others it'll be better to literally jump straight into the deep end. We can't say what will be the right way for you, you'll have to experiment for yourself, but you do have to expose yourself to falling.



Being aware of the potential dangers of climbing makes you alert and ensures you won't make mistakes that could have serious consequences.

These are some tips on how to become more comfortable with falling on lead:

1. The first fall is the worst fall. It'll get better.
2. Practise falling every time you go climbing until you're no longer afraid.
3. Visualise the fall in three segments: before falling, the fall itself, and the following swing. Go through the three parts with your belayer, and agree in advance on how long the fall should be and how much slack your belayer should give you.
4. Start with short, controlled falls indoors, where you give your belayer a heads-up before letting go. Continue with longer and longer falls indoors, and then progress outdoors. After a while, you'll be comfortable going for big moves and falling without needing to let your belayer know up front what's about to happen.

5. Start on an overhanging wall. You'll fall freely and won't have to worry about hitting anything on the way down.

6. Use an experienced belayer who knows how to give soft catches. A soft catch is important, as it lessens the swing and softens any potential impact, reducing all the forces at play.

7. As you get more comfortable falling, try giving yourself focus areas when climbing. Our experience is that we're never afraid when we have decided to send a route, because 'this is the attempt it's going to happen', and we're focusing on trying hard instead of falling. Many competition climbers feel the same way. They're never afraid during a competition, because they are too focused on the task at hand, but they might still feel fear during training. By setting a focus area you can trick your brain into not being afraid because it will be busy concentrating on something else instead.



Don't mess around with those who are afraid of falling! It's important for them to build confidence based on positive experiences. Giving unexpected falls or otherwise provoking the situation will only prolong their process significantly.



Maria Stangeland whipping into the weekend.

THE FIRST ASCENT OF BULDREIDIOTER by Martin Mobråten

A friend of mine, who is a safety manager for a rope access company, and I were trying to nab the first ascent of a route at Frigården outside of Trondheim, Norway. My friend fell at the third bolt and suddenly he was flat on the ground right beside me. He landed on his back on the grass right between three large rocks. He was fine, fortunately, and stood back up. As we looked up we saw the knot still dangling from the third quickdraw. It was obvious the figure of eight hadn't been completed as it should have been. The pre-climb safety check is always important and would have easily prevented the situation. We both got quite scared by the experience and have never forgotten the safety check since. We're now more aware of what can happen and are always alert when it comes to safety. We later sent the route and gave it the name Buldreidioter (Ed: 'Bouldering Idiots'), to reflect the fact that we mostly just do bouldering and were idiots to forget to check the knot.



PHOTO: ALEX MANELIS

Martin Moberg sending The Buttermilker (Font 8a+), Bishop, USA.

‘NEVER RESPECT GRADES.’

MARTIN MOBERG, 1999

FEAR OF FAILING

The fear of failing – performance anxiety – is a problem for many because it prevents them from trying moves, routes and exercises they think they will not master. This may be because they put too much pressure on themselves or experience a great deal of expectation from others. Although this fear can be devastating to both achievement and development, the fear of failure is an example of irrational fear. If this applies to you, work on it! Nothing will hinder your development more than avoiding even trying. Be pro-active and try technical, physical and mental challenges to improve. It's not the end of the world if you fail. Those who know you know how good you are, and the rest will not give it much thought if you fail. And why should you even care what others think? The climbers that impress us the most are the ones who dare to try and consider the process as helping them to develop further.

As we have mentioned many times in this book, one of the best things about climbing is the variety you can experience with different styles, walls and holds. This is what makes it a technically demanding sport and is a big part of why so many people think climbing is exciting and interesting. But this also presents a challenge. We all have a style, steepness and type of hold we prefer and are better at. Some may be lucky enough to have more than one skill, but few of us are equally good at everything. After many years as climbers and coaches, we see that some climbers prioritise most of their time in the style they are best at. And, in all honesty, so do we. Success gives us positive feedback, and it can be difficult to prioritise techniques that we are initially bad at. This can turn into a negative spiral, where you gradually become more and more sceptical of trying the techniques you do not master. But it's important to break this spiral. It's the styles we do not master that are the most important for us to practise, both for technical and mental reasons. For example, if you are poor at dynamic moves and want to become a better climber, then this is what you should practise. Even though clear and obvious results might elude you at first, begin the development process and try to find joy in your progression.

When we started climbing, F8b was about the hardest grade you could do on a rope in Norway, and the unofficial testpiece of Oslo was Marathon at Damtjern. It was the first of its grade in Norway and had not been repeated since Per Hustad's first ascent. Martin climbed the ranks relatively quickly when he started as a 14-year-old, but nobody expected him to try Marathon at only 16. Such grades were reserved only for the very strongest, those who had been training hard for a number of years, and not a skinny kid who had only climbed for a few years. Martin, on the other hand, thought otherwise. He hadn't climbed that many easier routes but he thought that if others could do it, so could he. Martin projected the route for a few days and, belayed by his father, he sent it in the late autumn of 1999. We have later thought about this and conclude that his lack of respect for the grade was one of the main reasons he sent the route. There were certainly more people who could have climbed it, but not many did. Most people thought it was too hard for them and never tried it. The role of youth has often been to break with the old ways of thinking and belief in what is possible, but here we could probably all improve. The youthful naiveté and belief in one's own abilities is an important starting point for improving. After Martin sent the route, there were others who followed. To many, it was an eye-opener and removed some of the respect that had been there for far too long.

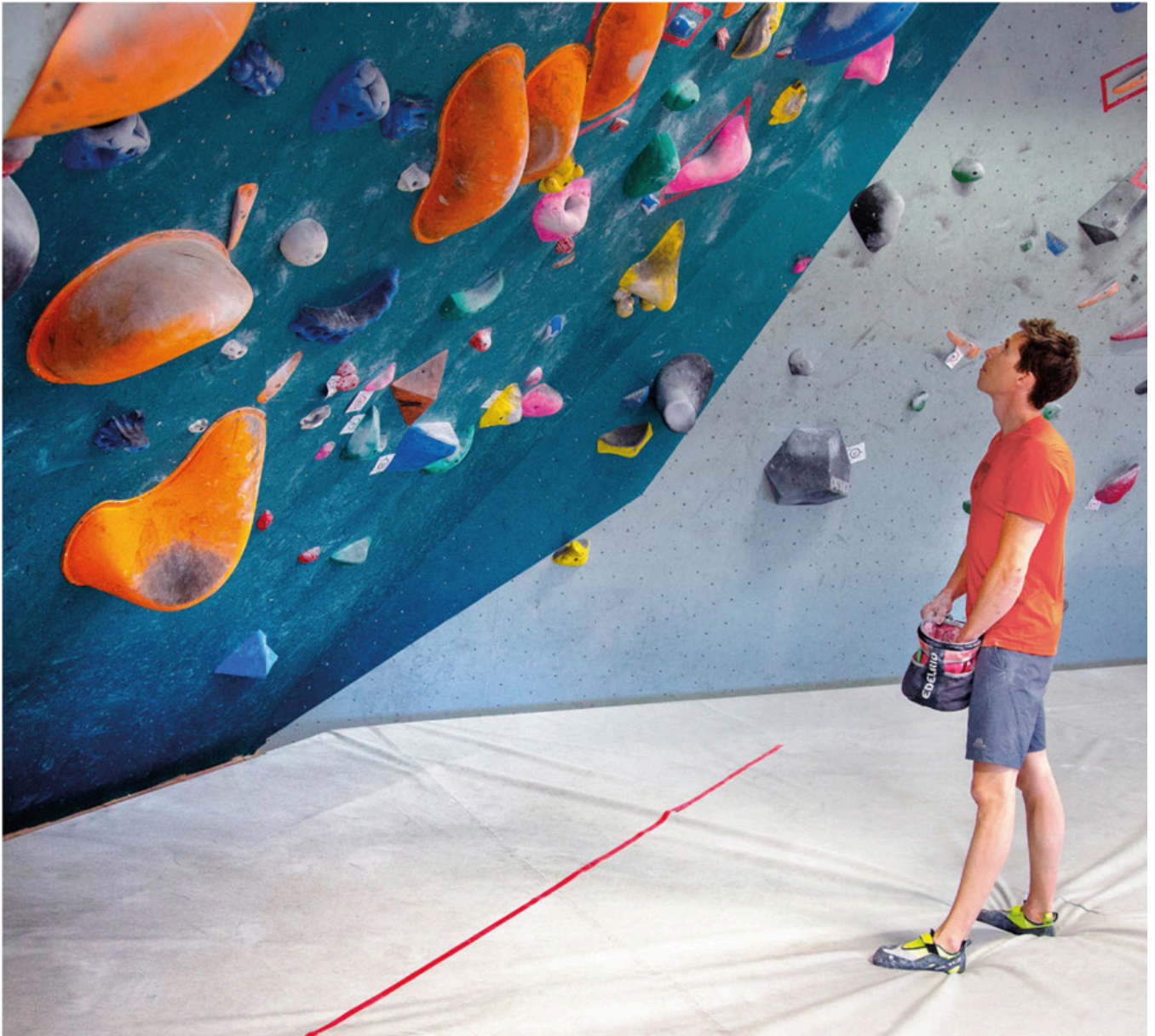
CONCENTRATION AND FOCUS

Concentration is important both when exercising and when trying to climb a route or a boulder problem. In order to have good concentration, it is important that we do not focus on too many things at the same time or that our minds are not occupied by unnecessary thoughts or outside disturbances. We must also be able to maintain concentration over time, while at the same time the varying challenges mean that we must concentrate on different tasks. Sports psychology usually distinguishes between inner, outer, narrow and wide concentration.

Inner concentration is when we concentrate on thoughts, feelings and feedback from physical movements, and when we make plans. Inner concentration is central when preparing to climb a route, when we are laying down the tactics for how to climb the next sequence on an on-sight, and when trying to calm down during relaxation exercises. During these preparations, it is often advisable to start with a wide inner concentration where we take into account all the factors that will be involved when climbing the route. All the factors are important to laying out good tactics, but before you start climbing, it is worthwhile to use a narrower concentration style focusing on routines and regulating your stress level. This is important to get you into the right mood for performance, because a wide inner style of planning the complicated tasks in front of you requires too many mental resources just before you get on the route, and can ruin the flow you need when you start to climb.

When you start climbing, you should generally put the inner concentration aside and focus on the outer elements. As long as you have prepared well before you start to climb, focusing too much on inner concentration when you are in the wall will only ruin your flow. You've probably experienced overthinking when climbing at some point. By analysing and evaluating the signals you're receiving from your body, the chances are that the route will feel harder than you expected. This is rarely of any benefit, so you should concentrate on external factors. Look at footholds to position your foot precisely, and concentrate on tasks such as flow and efficiency so you don't get too pumped too soon.

We also distinguish between wide and narrow outer concentration, and the difference is again how many simultaneous elements we take into account. In general, you should try to have a narrow outer concentration when climbing. Trying to take in all the different elements of the route as you climb will only have a negative effect. This will slow down your movements and you'll lose the flow you normally would have when you're 'just climbing'. It's better to focus on a single task such as precision or efficiency. The exceptions are when you are climbing on sight, don't remember the beta, or when you're working on a section of a route for future redpoint attempts. In these cases, you are often dependent on considering many external elements at the same time, such as hand and foot placements and from where to clip the next quickdraw. You'll then need a wider concentration than you would on a redpoint, as you have to take many different factors into account and not just execute the plan you have set in advance.



PLAYBOX

When you're climbing a route, you should concentrate on fewer and more specific tasks, like climbing with flow, relaxing at the rest, or really tightening up the core so you can take the swing you know is about to come. Execute – don't think!

THINKBOX

Before getting on a route or boulder problem, analyse and assess the different elements and make a plan for what you should do. Think about which hand sequence to use, which footholds are best, whether to do the crux move statically or dynamically and how you should position your body when matching the slopers. Leave the Thinkbox before starting the climb.



PHOTO: NATHAN WELTON

Rannveig Aamodt focusing before the next crux section.

‘THINKING WHEN CLIMBING IS A CLIMBER’S WORST ENEMY. YOU’LL HESITATE AND MISS THE HOLD.’

MARTIN MOBRÅTEN

You might also have to switch between inner and outer concentration when climbing on sight. You might need to plan ahead for sequences further up the route while you’re at a rest, and you might need to calm down after an unexpected crux that has suddenly appeared where you didn’t expect it to. At this point, your concentration is directed internally, but we believe that it’s important for you to direct the concentration back to external factors before continuing the climb. The same thing goes for when you’re working a route before a redpoint attempt. When you’re sitting in the harness and making a plan for how to execute the next sequence, that’s inner concentration, but when you tell your belayer that you’re about to give it a go, you should switch to a narrow outer concentration. In this regard, climbing differs from other individual sports because the tasks at hand require us to improvise and solve problems while climbing. We alternate between inner and outer and narrow and wide concentration all the time. In most other individual sports you train to perform a known task with few unforeseen and unknown factors. This is more like a redpoint send go. You know all the moves by heart, and all that’s left to do is to ‘just send it’. When it’s time to send, block out anything that does not fit into the narrow outer concentration.

It’s difficult to have the correct concentration, and it’s extra challenging when you’re forced to switch between narrow and wide and inner and outer. In addition to that, you often have to change what you’re focusing on within the same style of concentration. We find it useful to use a camera analogy to illustrate what we mean:

As with a camera we can zoom in or out to choose what should be in focus. If we wish to focus on details, we zoom in. By focusing only on that tiny foothold and blocking out everything else, we can increase the chance of us placing the foot correctly and it not slipping off. If we need more general focus, we zoom out. This can be flow, efficiency or precision, and is often the type of focus we need to send a route we’re familiar with. To get and maintain the right focus over time it can help to give yourself tasks during a climb. It’s important that these tasks are suited for the specific route or boulder problem, and they should be somewhat general. If you’re climbing a vertical indoor route, try focusing on precision footwork. If, on the other hand, you’re climbing a long and pumpy overhanging route, focus on dynamic flow. If a specific move requires it, zoom in, but be sure to zoom back out once the move is done.

Our experience is that you should zoom in only when strictly necessary. It can be hard to get back into rhythm if you start zooming in on details. Getting back into the right focus is a skill that can be trained, and the best way to do this is by specifying and focusing on concrete tasks when climbing. If you know you have to zoom in at a certain point during a climb, make sure to have a plan for getting your flow back. This can be as specific as planning to do the next ten moves quickly without any hesitation. By training these tasks, you’ll become more conscious of how and when you lose focus, and get better at getting back on track.

THE RIGHT FOCUS

Focus on the tasks, not the results! We hear stories about athletes who say they had the wrong focus when they failed. Often this is because they were focusing on the results rather than the simple tasks they had given themselves, and that their concentration shifted from outer to inner. We too make the same mistakes. When we're finally past the crux and all we have left is easy climbing to the top, we fail because our focus shifts to how it will feel when we succeed, or we start worrying about the consequences of failing now that we are finally past the crux.

Analyse any mistakes while you are on the ground, not when climbing. It's easy to think negative thoughts if something feels harder than it did last time, or if your foot slips and you have to waste energy to hang on. If the negative thoughts are creeping in, you need to shut the door on them and turn that mental frown upside down.

Ignore unforeseen things that happen. It's easy to lose focus if you suddenly get to a wet hold, or if there are lots of people watching you, or if the friction is bad. These things happen when you climb, and it's important that you keep your thoughts from turning sour. Be selective, ignore noise and disturbances, and focus on the tasks at hand.



Climbers with good technique often have an easier time keeping focus. They aren't as dependent on zooming in on every little detail of every move, and they can more easily maintain a wider overview.

ROUTINES AND RITUALS

Routines and rituals are important tools for increasing concentration and creating the right focus. The routines aim to make sure that the preparations in advance are as good as possible and that you are ready to perform. Examples of routines can be to warm up the same way every time, to rest for 15 minutes after the warm-up, to visualise the route or the boulder problem, and to talk to yourself in a certain way before pulling on. It can also be a song or a music genre that puts you in that try-hard mood, or closing your eyes and taking three deep breaths right before you start.

Rituals differ from routines in that they are not clearly or objectively related to the performance. They may be important to your performance, but it is far from certain that the same ritual will make sense to your climbing partner. Rituals are often associated with superstition and are often related to earlier success, seemingly, but randomly, caused by doing something in particular. Rituals are important to many climbers, as they can strengthen their faith in success. Examples of rituals can be to always put on the left climbing shoe before the right, or wearing a special pair of lucky trousers. If your belief in your success increases when you put your left shoe on before the right then that's a good thing, but it probably has no significance beyond that.

For routines and rituals to be useful, it is important that they are feasible, not too comprehensive, and that you yourself are in control of the content. If they make you dependent on others or are difficult to control, consider changing them. For example, if you need to eat a particular type of food that might be hard to get hold of before climbing, or you have to climb with a particular pair of trousers which might actually be a bit too dirty some days, consider whether this is truly necessary for you in order to perform. There are also many unforeseen factors that can be difficult to control, such as sudden rainfall just before your attempt, a shift in the competition day schedule, or a hold that breaks during the warm-up. Don't be too tied to your routines and rituals, and have a plan B ready in case of unforeseen events.

Most climbers have routines and rituals, although not everyone is aware of them. If you don't have any, we recommend that you think about what you tend to do and pick out two or three things to repeat from now on before climbing. Find your own routines for warming up, visualising and relaxing. You may have some rituals as well, just make sure they're possible to recreate under most conditions. How about a fist bump with your climbing partner, or slapping yourself lightly on the chest to wake up? It doesn't have to have any meaning other than that you believe in it yourself. Routines and rituals don't have to be static, you can change them, but many climbers stick to the same things for a long time. They can also be customised to the route or the boulder you are getting on. On a technical and precise route, it may be appropriate that the last thing you do is close your eyes and take some deep breaths to calm yourself down. You will lower your stress level and be better equipped to focus on precision footwork and using the small footholds. On a brutally physical boulder problem, it might be better to get psyched by tightening your muscles and breathing quickly. This will increase your stress level and make you ready to pull as hard as you can.



Routines and rituals don't have to be reserved for only hard attempts. By actively using them during training you will also be able to perform better there. For example, visualisation and music help give you the right level of arousal and concentration even for static and 'simple' exercises.





PHOTO: ALEX MANELIS

Maria Davies Sandbu collecting her thoughts and lowering her stress level before the technical slab top-out on a highball in Bishop, USA.

STRESS LEVEL AND CONTROL

Our stress (or arousal) level is how calm or tense we are in different situations. At a low stress level we relax and use less energy, while at a higher stress level we are ready to pull hard. On a technically challenging route that demands balance and precision, or on long, pumpy routes, it may be appropriate to lower the stress level. On short, hard and explosive boulders or routes, however, it's more appropriate to increase the stress level. An additional challenge in climbing is that there will be sections on routes and boulders that require different levels of arousal. A technically challenging section of vertical climbing can be followed by a brutal and bouldery crux through steeper terrain, and a steep and hard boulder problem might finish with a balancy and delicate top-out. So you should be able to regulate and control your stress level before a climb, and also during a climb.

‘I’M FEELING NERVOUS – GOOD!’

JERRY MOFFATT

Stress levels are individual. Some climbers have a low base level and have to psyche themselves up to get into the right mood, while others have a higher base level and might need to calm down before climbing. Even though different aspects of climbing require different levels of stress, we would argue that most of us are too tense when climbing. It is usually only for individual moves that we will benefit from a high stress level, while in most cases it's better to stay more relaxed. Give this some thought the next time you go climbing. Are you too tense, gripping the holds harder than necessary, or are you relaxed and climbing with as little effort as possible? If you fall into the former category of climber, this is most likely caused by your stress level being too high.

You've probably at some point experienced butterflies before getting on a route you've been trying. This is a result of a heightened stress level caused by you wanting to send the route. For some this nervousness can be rather destructive, while for others it's exactly what they need to perform at their best. How you respond to the increased stress will decide if it's positive or not. If you want to expose yourself to situations where your stress level will rise and you get nervous, you have to also learn how to deal with it in the best way possible. For example, you could tell yourself that you're getting nervous because sending the route means something to you, that this is what you've trained for, and that you've actually reached a level where you're able to send your project. A positive inner dialogue can help you interpret your nervousness into something positive and desirable, and consequently lower your stress level to something more appropriate.



Know yourself! Knowing what tension level you are at, and what level you should be at for a particular route, the easier it will be to adjust to the correct level. Muscles in top gear paired with a calm mental state is the best combination in our experience.

One of the more tangible tools we have for controlling our stress level both before and during a climb is our breathing. If you are nervous before climbing, or just need to lower your stress level, try focusing on taking slow, deep breaths. Slowly fill your chest and stomach with air and exhale through your nose five to six times, and notice how your pulse drops and your breathing stabilises. On the other hand, if you need to increase your stress level, take multiple short, quick breaths to increase your pulse and arousal. It's also important to notice how you're breathing while climbing. On harder sections, most climbers have a tendency to hold their breath, and even though this might be beneficial on really hard individual moves, it's important to try to maintain a slow and steady breathing pattern. And thus, focusing on your breathing during a climb can be a helpful tool for climbing naturally.



Dancing elegantly on small holds on vertical walls requires you to relax and trust your feet, while burly undercling moves on your mega-project require you to gear up and increase arousal.

Focus on breathing faster and increasing your pulse if you know you're about to enter a brutal section, and focus on slowing your breathing and calming down when approaching a technical slab section. If you find yourself at a good place to rest, use this time to breathe and relax to make sure that you're recovering as quickly as possible. In the same way as before starting the climb, control your breathing and inhale/exhale deeply to lower your pulse and relax in the position.

Controlling the stress level is an important mental technique for optimum performance, and it will require a lot of experimentation to figure out what works best for you. Below are some tips on how you can regulate your stress level before and during a climb:

- Good routines and rituals before a climb help to set the right stress level. Vary the contents of your routines according to the appropriate stress level for what you're climbing. For example, try listening to harder music to increase arousal and calm music to lower stress.
- Use familiar warm-up routines that you know will get you in the right mood.
- Use a positive inner dialogue to build confidence and gear up/down before and during a climb.
- Be conscious of your breathing before and during a climb. Calm, deep breaths lower stress, while quick breaths increase arousal. Use this actively to gear up/down. If you're getting stressed while run out above the last bolt, try taking a few deep breaths.
- Shout and scream to gear up during a climb.
- A pre-climb fist bump helps to set the right mood and stress level.

STRESS LEVEL

Does the way we train cause us to climb with higher stress levels than necessary? Many climbers focus primarily on physical training and don't prioritise technique, tactics and mental training. By focusing only on the physical aspects, your body and mind will learn that the only way to the top is by always pulling as hard as you can. This leads you to subconsciously increase your stress level even when it's not really necessary for a particular climb. This underlines the message of The Climbing Bible. The physical aspects are important for climbing performance, but they are not the only ones. By spending more time training technique and the mental aspects of climbing, in time you'll learn to climb more relaxed and efficiently.

VISUALISATION

Visualisation is one of the most commonly used mental techniques for increasing performance in sports and means, in short, imagining doing the task at hand before starting it. Visualisation is used, among other things, to practise techniques, to envisage tactical plans and goal achievement, and to regulate the stress level. For us climbers, the positive effects of visualisation are:

- remembering moves and sequences
- building confidence and finding the right focus
- setting the appropriate stress level
- preparation.

VISUALISE SUCCESS

It's important that you're always visualising success. This means always visualising yourself climbing all the way to the top of the route or topping out the boulder problem. If you can't visualise yourself doing the crux, or the movie stops playing because you get too pumped at the top of the route, you need to practise visualising actually doing the whole route. If you do end up falling when trying the route, you should still visualise climbing all the way to the top as soon as you get back down to the ground. Emphasise how to get past the point where you just fell off. Rebuild faith in being able to do the route as quickly as possible and don't think too much about failing and that you might even fall at the same point again.

Getting good at visualisation requires training, but the rewards can be significant. It has been estimated that the world's best athletes in a variety of sports spend about fifteen minutes each day visualising, and although us mere mortals probably do not need to visualise to the same extent, we should practise it every time we climb. We distinguish between two types of visualisation: dissociated and associated visualisation.

Dissociated visualisation is visualising oneself in the third person. Imagine that you are a character in a movie on TV. Then create the movie in your head as you go through the different parts of the route or the boulder problem you are going to climb. Try to make it as detailed as possible. As a first step to learning this technique, begin by going through a simple task like tying yourself into your harness. Imagine picking up the rope, tying the knot and double-checking that it is tied correctly. When you feel comfortable using the technique on simple tasks, you can start trying it out on the actual climbing. Start with a route you've tried or climbed before. Before you try to climb it, you can imagine how to chalk your hands before you start, how to clip the first quickdraw, where to place your feet on the crux and how to hold the tiny crimp. Include as many details as possible and create a movie that shows the whole process of sending the route, including all the moves right to the top.

Associated visualisation is visualising oneself in the first person. You should try to see and feel what you want to see and feel when you actually climb the route or boulder problem. In other words, the movie you are about to make is more detailed than the one you would make for dissociated visualisation, and the goal is to provide as complete an experience as possible. To practise this technique, you can perform the same tasks as before, such as tying yourself in, but now in the first person. Include what you see as you do it. Also, include other sensations and consider if it's cold, what sounds you hear and how the rope feels between your hands. Once you've practised this technique on simpler tasks, it's time to do it with a climbing route or a boulder problem. Begin with a route you've tried before, so you know how the different parts of the route will feel. Start with the feeling you have before you climb. Are you excited? Nervous? Calm? Try to think of what is appropriate for this particular route. Then move on to the climb itself. Imagine how you're clipping the first quickdraw efficiently, how you're making sure you're placing your foot accurately on the slopey foothold at the crux, and how you feel when you're bearing down on the tiny crimp. Also, include the feeling of getting pumped on the last part of the route after the crux. Prepare to get pumped, but in a good way. Not the kind of pump you get when you're cold and unprepared, but the kind where your forearms are warm, the kind you get because you warmed up well and prepared. You know that you can endure this pump for a good while and that you can climb well all the way to the top even if you are pumped.





Try to block out any outside noise and don't get disturbed when visualising.

Dissociated visualisation is the easiest form of visualisation. This is the type you should start with if you are new to visualisation, and it will be the appropriate first step in visualising routes you haven't climbed before. It gives you an initial overview of the moves, where to clip the draws and any changes in tempo. It is also the best technique when on-sighting since you're not familiar with the details of the route, and it can be difficult to use associated visualisation if you don't have much experience in climbing on sight. Once you have tried the route or the boulder problem, it is useful to use associated visualisation to learn the different moves and sections, and to create a sense of what it is like to climb them. We think this form of visualisation is the best, and should always be used whenever possible. This will give you the right focus and stress level before you start climbing. The movie you make has to be a positive one. If you can't imagine yourself succeeding, it will be difficult to succeed in practice. To achieve this, you can start by remembering your last good attempt, or any other positive experience. Then go through the entire route and prepare yourself for how you will be thinking at the different sections. Feel your body doing the moves before you start, and picture yourself succeeding. Then you are ready!

If you want to analyse mistakes you have made or dangerous situations that may occur on routes, you should use dissociated and not associated visualisation. Mistakes should be analysed as objectively as possible, without being clouded by too much emotion. Associated visualisation of dangerous elements on routes will only make you more afraid than what is appropriate.

When training, you should alternate between associated and dissociated visualisation. For endurance training and pure strength exercises that you're familiar with, it might be best to stick with dissociated visualisation so as not to be thinking too much about how tiring or painful it can get. You should imagine yourself being able to complete the exercises, but don't focus on how you have to feel to get there. It's going to hurt, and there is no point in thinking too much about it beforehand. When practising technique, associated visualisation is a must. You have to familiarise yourself with all aspects of the movement and pay attention to the feedback you're receiving from your senses. Imagine doing a dyno: try to picture the starting position, the jump, and how you'll land the next hold. It's hard to get a good idea of how a position will feel if you don't see it in the first person.

As we've discussed many times in this book, improvisation is an important part of climbing. With visualisation, it can be easy to get locked into climbing a sequence the way we imagine it will be solved. This is particularly true for on-sights. You've looked at the holds from the ground and come up with a solution for what seems to be the crux and figured out where to rest. Similarly, you have an idea of the sequence for your left and right hands, and where to place your feet. So what happens when this doesn't work out? Maybe it's the slab at the top of the route that is the crux, and not the steep overhang in the middle as you first thought. To allow for such unforeseen things, you should add different solutions for the various sections into your visualisation, if possible. At the same time, mentally prepare for how to respond if the climb feels different to what you anticipated. You will then be much better equipped to deal with these challenges. Sometimes you will also have to stop halfway up the route and visualise the road ahead. This can happen when you face surprising cruxes, and you have to make a whole new plan. In the section on concentration, we wrote that you should generally not switch to an inner concentration style after you have started to climb, but in this case, it is actually necessary. You need to focus away from the task you had up to this point, adopt a broader and more analytical inner concentration style, and make a plan for what is to come. If you need to do this while climbing, find a rest or a point on the route that allows you time to think, and shift your focus back to an executive task, such as flow or efficiency, when the plan has been set.



Watch a bouldering competition on YouTube and notice how the climbers read the problems in advance. They'll often do more than just plan their hand and foot placements, especially if the problems have elements that require coordination. You'll see them testing the body positions by miming them while still on the ground. It might look strange, but it works!



MAKING A MAP

When you're climbing in lead competitions, you won't normally get to see the other climbers on the route before it's your turn. The only information you have about the route is what you can see during the few minutes of common observation time. After the observation is over, all the climbers have to wait in the isolation area until it's their turn to climb. When we started competing many years ago, we always drew a map of the routes on a sheet of paper while waiting in isolation. We tried drawing it as accurately as we could remember while discussing how to solve the sequences. This way we made a plan on how to climb the whole route. We planned which holds to use and with which hand, where to stand, where to clip the draws, and so on. We also made a plan for where we believed we could rest, and where we had to climb fast.

As a last element, before it was our turn to climb, we used to shut our eyes, lower our pulse and stress level, and picture how we were going to feel when on the wall. We were rarely ever not psyched enough, so it was important to calm down before starting to climb. This whole routine of drawing the map and lowering the stress level made visualising easier, and in the long run, it improved our visualisation skills.



PHOTO: MIKE HUTTON

Mari Augusta Salvesen on Master's Edge (E7 6c), Millstone Edge, Peak District, England.

